Management
Decision

Resource-based faultlines and creativity: employee boundary-spanning and team motivational climate

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Received 6 June 2024
Revised 6 October 2024
9 February 2025
18 May 2025
6 August 2025
Accepted 13 December 2025

Abstract

Purpose – Drawing on conservation of resources (COR) theory, this study develops a theoretical model to explain how and under what conditions resource-based faultlines influence employee creativity, emphasizing the mediating role of employee boundary-spanning behavior and the moderating role of team motivational climate.

Design/methodology/approach – Data were gathered from 336 employees nested within 65 teams using a two-wave, multi-source research design. Multilevel modeling was employed to test the proposed theoretical framework.

Findings – Resource-based faultlines reduce employee boundary-spanning behavior, which in turn diminishes employee creativity. This indirect negative relationship is strengthened by team performance motivational climate but weakened by team mastery motivational climate.

Originality/value – This study advances prior research by shifting the focus from surface-level faultlines to resource-based faultlines and integrating COR theory to explain their cross-level effects on employee boundary-spanning behavior and creativity. It further distinguishes the moderating effects of performance versus mastery motivational climates, providing a more nuanced understanding of how team climate shapes behavioral and creative responses to resource asymmetries. The findings contribute to the team faultlines literature and offer practical guidance for enhancing employee creativity through team composition and climate management.

Keywords Team resource-based faultlines, Employee creativity, Employee boundary-spanning behavior, Team motivational climate

Paper type Research article

1. Introduction

In an era marked by intensified external competition and increasing internal demands for high-quality development, particularly in the rapidly evolving AI landscape, employee creativity has emerged as a critical factor in determining organizational competitiveness in dynamic markets (Amabile, 1988; Rasheed and Jianhua, 2023; Zhang and Chen, 2023). Given its importance, extensive research has explored the antecedents and consequences of employee creativity. A critical factor significantly affecting individual creativity is the presence of resource-based faultlines within teams. However, focusing solely on the effects of resource-based faultlines on team creativity (Yao and Liu, 2023) may overlook the complex underlying dynamics. Such faultlines can activate diverse mechanisms, causing employees to respond variably to similar circumstances (Bezrukova *et al.*, 2009), ultimately affecting their innovative output (Carton and Cummings, 2012). Investigating individual creativity within teams enables organizations to better identify and support employees affected by resource-based faultlines, thereby enhancing creativity at both team and organizational levels (Greer *et al.*, 2017). Furthermore, addressing internal resource depletion and fostering creativity in resource-constrained teams represents a significant management challenge with substantial practical implications (Magee and Galinsky, 2008).

Previous research has primarily focused on surface-level faultlines associated with demographic characteristics, such as social category and informational faultlines. However,

Funding: This research was supported by the National Natural Science Foundation of China (71572140).

Management Decision
© Emerald Publishing Limited
e-ISSN: 1758-6070
p-ISSN: 0025-1747
DOI 10.1108/MD-06-2024-1269

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deeper faultlines often emerge as teams evolve, transcending demographic traits, particularly resource-based faultlines, which refer to perceived or assumed divisions among team members based on alignments in resource-related attributes, including decision-making authority, power, and status (Yao and Liu, 2023; Carton and Cummings, 2012). Such perceived divisions can result in unequal resource distribution within teams, as members differ in their control over valuable social and material resources (Greer *et al.*, 2017). Among different types of faultlines, resource-based faultlines are more likely to be activated due to disparities in essential social resources, such as power, status, influence, and decision-making authority. These resources are often obtained through high-quality leader–member exchange relationships, significantly influencing an individual's ability to access them (Li and Liao, 2014). Access to such resources is also closely associated with career advancement and economic rewards. Because of their inherently social nature, resource-based faultlines strongly influence employee performance. Compared to social category and informational faultlines, they are more readily activated and more directly affect team members' social interactions and individual creativity. Given the importance of social resources for team functioning, disparities in resource distribution can significantly shape members' attitudes and behaviors in decision-making processes (Amabile and Pratt, 2016).

Despite extensive research documenting how social category faultlines (e.g. gender, age, and race) and informational faultlines (e.g. education, tenure, and functional background) influence team and individual outcomes (Bezrukova *et al.*, 2009), insights into the effects of resource-based faultlines have developed more slowly (Carton and Cummings, 2012; Yao and Liu, 2023). Most empirical studies have concentrated on the relationship between resource-based faultlines and team performance (Yao and Liu, 2023), with limited attention paid to their cross-level effects on individual employee outcomes. This gap constrains our understanding of the multilevel mechanisms through which resource-based faultlines shape employee outcomes, particularly as employee creativity is essential for organizations to navigate unforeseen challenges and succeed in dynamic environments (Zhou and Hoever, 2014). Therefore, exploring how and when team-level resource-based faultlines affect employee creativity meaningfully advances current faultlines research. It also responds to recent calls for greater attention to the cross-level applicability of organizational theories. Therefore, by examining the cross-level linkage between team-level resource-based faultlines and employee creativity, this study aims to enhance understanding of the multilevel dynamics that shape employee outcomes.

Employee access to resources occurs both within the team and externally, with individual boundary-spanning behavior playing a pivotal role in securing external resources (Marrone *et al.*, 2007). Boundary-spanning behavior refers to employees' engagement in team activities and connections with external stakeholders to access resources (Marrone, 2010). These activities play a crucial role in the innovation process (Tortoriello and Krackhardt, 2010), as they provide essential knowledge, information, and other resources that enhance employees' sense of innovative efficacy (Shin and Zhou, 2007), which, in turn, forms the basis for individual creativity (Liu *et al.*, 2018; Zhang and Li, 2021). Drawing upon the COR theory, individuals prioritize conserving existing resources when facing potential threats (Hobfoll, 1989, 2001). In the context of teams, resource-based faultlines can undermine members' internal resources by intensifying competition and conflict over resource allocation (Zhang *et al.*, 2017). When such threats emerge, employees may have insufficient personal energy to address both internal and external demands, leading them to reduce engagement in boundary-spanning behavior to conserve resources. This withdrawal, however, deprives them of essential external inputs for innovation, ultimately impeding their creativity (Amabile, 1988; Amabile and Pratt, 2016). Therefore, we propose that employee boundary-spanning behavior may serve as the mediating mechanism linking team resource-based faultlines and employee creativity.

COR theory suggests that environmental conditions, such as team climate, can either nurture or restrict individual resources (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018; Kanfer and Chen, 2016). Team

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climate is critical in shaping employees' behaviors, particularly regarding resource distribution and perceived disparities (Černe *et al.*, 2014; Haynie *et al.*, 2014). Distinct types of climate set different expectations for employee behavior. For instance, a team innovation climate encourages members to propose or experiment with novel ideas (Anderson and West, 1998), while a team voice climate fosters a shared perception of support for suggestions (Morrison *et al.*, 2011). Among various forms of team climate, team motivational climate is especially influential, as it profoundly influences the policies, processes, and practices within a team's work environment (Nerstad *et al.*, 2013). It shapes employees' task-related attitudes and social interactions, crucial for fostering an innovative spirit and enhancing individual capabilities (Černe *et al.*, 2014). To better understand the role of team motivational climate, we follow Nicholls (1989) and Nerstad *et al.* (2013), who categorize this climate into two dimensions: team performance motivational climate, which focuses on specific performance results, and team mastery motivational climate, which emphasizes individual development, effort, and learning. This distinction provides clearer expectations regarding how employees are encouraged to behave and engage in creative processes (Schulte *et al.*, 2009; Nerstad *et al.*, 2018). Understanding these distinctions is vital, as an appropriately aligned team motivational climate may buffer the adverse effects of resource-based faultlines by enhancing employees' motivation to engage in boundary-spanning behavior and supporting creative expression. Conversely, a misaligned climate may exacerbate resource threats and suppress creative engagement. Accordingly, we introduce team motivational climate as a moderating variable in the research framework to explore how it conditions the relationship between resource-based faultlines and employee creativity. Specifically, we aim to identify which type of motivational climate can alleviate or intensify the adverse effects of resource-based faultlines.

Our research makes several theoretical contributions. First, we advance the understanding of the multilevel effects of team resource-based faultlines on employee creativity. While previous research has predominantly focused on surface-level demographic faultlines (e.g. social category or informational faultlines) (Carton and Cummings, 2012; Qu and Liu, 2017), deeper-level faultlines, such as resource-based faultlines, have received comparatively less scholarly attention despite their widespread presence in organizational teams. Extending the work of Shin *et al.* (2012), who examined the cross-level effects of team cognitive diversity on individual creativity, this study further explores how resource-based faultlines influence individual creativity across levels. Second, we underscore the influence of team resource-based faultlines on employee boundary-spanning behavior and emphasize the mediating role of such behavior between resource-based faultlines and employee creativity. The "within and outside team" viewpoint reveals how internal resource disparities may restrict team members' external engagement, including their willingness to engage in boundary-spanning behavior, thereby suppressing creative outcomes. Third, by distinguishing between team performance motivational climate and team mastery motivational climate, we provide a more nuanced understanding of how distinct team climates influence employee behavior and creativity in resource-based faultlines. Figure 1 presents the overall theoretical model.

2. Theoretical background and hypothesis development

2.1 Team resource-based faultlines and conservation of resources (COR) theory

Faultlines have become a central topic in organizational research (Mathieu *et al.*, 2008). Lau and Murnighan (1998) introduced the concept of team faultlines within team diversity theory, defining them as hypothetical dividing lines that emerge from combinations of differences across one or more attributes. Researchers typically classify faultlines into three types: social category faultlines, informational faultlines, and resource-based faultlines. Social category faultlines stem from surface-level attributes such as gender, age, and race, whereas informational faultlines arise from differences in education, functional background, and professional expertise (Carton and Cummings, 2012; Harrison and Klein, 2007). In contrast,

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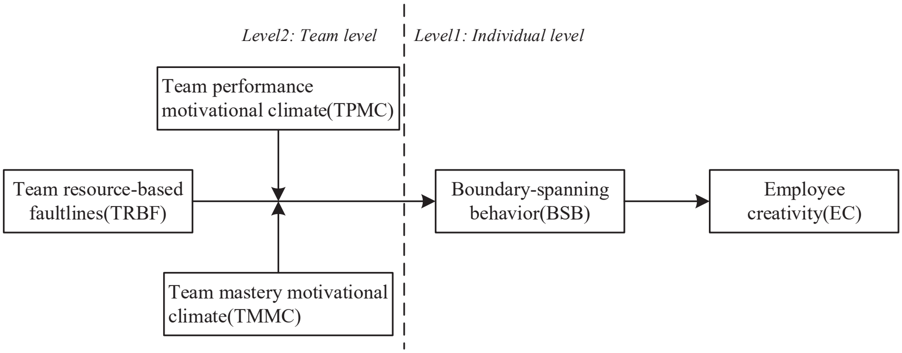

Figure 1. Hypothesized model. **Source(s):** Authors' own work

resource-based faultlines result from disparities in power, status, and decision-making authority, formed by aligning resource-related attributes (Carton and Cummings, 2012; Yao and Liu, 2023). Understanding resource-based faultlines requires attention to aggregating individual traits into identifiable attribute patterns (Bezrukova *et al.*, 2009). High-intensity resource-based faultlines typically produce a "pyramid-shaped" team structure, with a "dominant subgroup" controlling a disproportionate share of resources and "subordinate subgroups" holding comparatively less (Carton and Cummings, 2012). In contrast, low-intensity faultlines signal a more equitable distribution of resources across team members (Zhang *et al.*, 2017).

A key characteristic of faultlines is their context-dependent and dynamic nature. Activated faultlines can trigger subgroup categorization and intergroup bias, emphasizing the need for context-sensitive interpretations (Spoelma and Ellis, 2017). Rather than objective measures, activated faultlines exert more potent effects on team dynamics, particularly when team members acknowledge and respond to these faultlines (Antino *et al.*, 2019; Jehn and Bezrukova, 2010). For example, activated gender faultlines substantially affect team creativity more than dormant ones (Pearsall *et al.*, 2008). Accordingly, this study focuses on activated team resource-based faultlines, defined as team members' perceptions of disparities in resource allocation, such as power, status, and decision-making authority.

COR theory proposes that individuals strive to preserve, protect, and acquire valuable resources, with their perceptions of resource standing firmly shaping their attitudes and behaviors (Hobfoll, 1989). The theory's loss-first principle suggests that resource loss carries a greater psychological impact than resource gain. Thus, when facing potential loss, individuals prioritize preserving current resources rather than pursuing new ones (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018). In team dynamics, resource-based faultlines reflect disparities in power and status, which affect member interactions and activate self-protective behaviors (Tost *et al.*, 2013). A high level of activated resource-based faultlines signals potential resource competition, prompting members to focus on resource retention rather than securing external resources. Members who control more resources often gain access to additional social assets such as power, status, and decision-making authority, enabling them to influence team processes (Hildreth and Anderson, 2016). However, these advantages may also increase risk aversion, limiting their willingness to propose or support creative ideas. Conversely, members with fewer resources may feel pressured to conform to the preferences of dominant subgroups (Greer and van Kleef, 2010). Motivated by concerns about internal conflict and external demands, they also emphasize resource protection, as acquisition efforts entail high perceived costs (Wei *et al.*, 2024). This tendency can reinforce conservative behavior across the team, ultimately undermining innovation and collaboration.

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2.2 Resource-based faultlines, employee boundary-spanning behavior, and employee creativity

Employee boundary-spanning behavior refers to individuals' actions to enhance organizational effectiveness by interacting with external stakeholders outside the organization's formal boundaries (Ancona, 1990). These behaviors typically require attunement to the external environment, access to valuable information, and the acquisition of diverse and innovative resources (Katz and Tushman, 1983). Significantly, such external engagement is deeply influenced by the internal dynamics of the teams to which individuals belong.

As resource-based faultlines intensify within teams, hostility and detrimental intergroup friction may emerge, leading to heightened competition and conflict (Zanutto *et al.*, 2011). Such dynamics strain interpersonal relationships among employees (Eby and Russell, 2000; Streich *et al.*, 2008). When potential resource conflicts arise, employees may cultivate self-interested motives, prioritizing the protection of internal resources over seeking or monitoring of external ones (Tjosvold, 1986; Wang *et al.*, 2024). According to COR theory, as faultlines become more pronounced and resources become increasingly concentrated in the hands of a few, employees are likely to adopt defensive strategies to preserve their existing resources (Halbesleben and Wheeler, 2011, 2015). In these situations, both intra-team and extra-team competition intensifies, making pursuing additional resources more costly and effortful (Wei *et al.*, 2024). Members of dominant subgroups, who possess a larger share of resources, are more inclined to safeguard their existing advantages, as engaging in boundary-spanning activities may expose them to additional risks and competition (Halbesleben and Wheeler, 2011). Conversely, when interacting with external entities during boundary-spanning activities, subordinate subgroup members may be viewed as "outsiders", thereby increasing their risk of marginalization (Lau and Murnighan, 1998). To prevent further depletion of their limited resources, these employees are more likely to withdraw from boundary-spanning activities (Patel and Cooper, 2014).

Employee boundary-spanning behavior is inherently relational, depending on sustained connections with both external clients and internal team members. Employees must continuously monitor the external environment, whether performing boundary-spanning tasks as part of their formal role or engaging in them voluntarily as extra-role behaviors. They need to extract valuable information from the rapidly changing external landscape, translate it into comprehensible knowledge for their team, and communicate it effectively (Katz and Tushman, 1983). This complex process demands considerable time and energy. Therefore, under pronounced resource-based faultlines, employees tend to reduce boundary-spanning activities that deplete their time and energy, seeking to avert further resource loss, as predicted by COR theory. In such environments, dominant subgroup members, who already possess substantial internal resources, are generally less inclined to invest effort in acquiring additional external resources, preferring instead to safeguard their current advantages. In contrast, subordinate subgroup members primarily focus on safeguarding what they have despite their limited access to internal resources. Individuals experiencing resource depletion are less likely to invest their remaining resources and energy in boundary-spanning activities, further diminishing their engagement in such behaviors (Hobfoll, 2001).

Conversely, when resource-based faultlines are low, resource differentiation among team members is less pronounced. This more egalitarian distribution fosters a collaborative and inclusive power-sharing model, where team members perceive their environment as equitable and communal, thereby promoting mutual respect. In such contexts, team members who engage in boundary-spanning behaviors are more likely to receive peer support and recognition (Hirst *et al.*, 2011). This supportive team climate enhances the capacity and motivation of individuals to undertake boundary-spanning behaviors (Seibert *et al.*, 2017).

Although the effects of team resource-based faultlines on employee boundary-spanning behavior may appear consistent across dominant and subordinate subgroups, the underlying motivations differ according to individuals' levels of resource control. This interpretation

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provides a more nuanced perspective on how team resource-based faultlines influence individual behaviors. Based on these insights, we propose the following hypothesis:

H1. Team resource-based faultlines are negatively related to employee boundary-spanning behavior.

Boundary-spanning behavior plays a critical role in enhancing employee creativity. Employees who engage in such behaviors expand their cognitive frameworks and skill sets, thereby enhancing creativity (Kim *et al.*, 2022; Chien *et al.*, 2021). Specifically, when team resources are constrained, employees may perceive internal resources as inadequate to meet work demands. This awareness motivates them to shift attention toward the external environment to seek complementary resources that support team goals (Choi, 2002). Through boundary-spanning, they obtain valuable task-related suggestions and information from external stakeholders (Burt, 2004; Marrone, 2010) and integrate novel, heterogeneous resources into the organization. Such integration complements existing team resources and fosters innovation through enhanced information sharing (Dahiyat, 2015).

A lack of adequate resources can substantially impede individual creativity (Amabile, 1988). Without access to essential resources, individuals may find it difficult to identify problems and generate new solutions or ideas (De Jonge *et al.*, 2012). Thus, boundary-spanning behaviors are vital, as they facilitate the acquisition of diverse and valuable resources, such as knowledge and information, that are essential for stimulating creativity (Shin and Zhou, 2007). Additionally, applying these acquired resources within the team can trigger meaningful transformations in employees' knowledge bases, further boosting creativity (Amabile and Pratt, 2016). Prior research has demonstrated that employee boundary-spanning behavior not only facilitates innovation processes (Amabile and Pratt, 2016), but also heightens employees' awareness of proactive innovation opportunities (Lingo and O'Mahony, 2010), ultimately leading to enhanced creativity (Lin and Li, 2013; Liu *et al.*, 2018).

The analysis above illustrates the adverse effects of team resource-based faultlines on employee boundary-spanning behavior and creativity, highlighting the positive influence of boundary-spanning behavior in enhancing employee creativity. This behavior serves as a vital conduit for accessing external resources necessary to stimulate employee creativity, which depends on how resources are linked and shared within the team (Sparrowe *et al.*, 2001). As established in prior discussions, resource-based faultlines negatively affect employee boundary-spanning behavior, while such behavior positively influences employee creativity. Thus, we propose that employee boundary-spanning behavior functions as a key mediating mechanism connecting team resource-based faultlines with employee creativity, thereby transmitting the detrimental effects of resource-based faultlines on creativity. Based on these insights, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H2. Employee boundary-spanning behavior mediates the relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee creativity.

2.3 The moderating role of team motivational climate

The environment serves as both a facilitator and a constraint on behavior (Mowday and Sutton, 1993), influencing employee actions (Bamberger, 2008). Decisions to engage in innovative work frequently depend on individuals' perceptions of success and failure, which are determined by the team motivational climate and formed through team members' shared perceptions (Ames, 1995). Recent research in management and psychology has expanded the conceptualization of motivational climate from an individual-level construct to a team-level phenomenon. Motivational climate refers to team members' collective perceptions regarding criteria for success and failure (Nerstad *et al.*, 2013).

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Team motivational climate is typically categorized into team performance motivational climate (TPMC) and team mastery motivational climate (TMMC). TPMC emphasizes normative standards and internal competition (Roberts, 2012), cultivating a climate characterized by social comparison and rivalry (Ntoumanis and Biddle, 1999). This climate is commonly associated with performance-oriented behaviors such as goal attainment, individual advancement, and competitive interactions among team members (Černe *et al.*, 2014). In contrast, TMMC prioritizes learning, self-development, and collaboration (Ames, 1995), fostering skill acquisition and cooperative task execution. This orientation promotes knowledge sharing, well-being, job satisfaction, and team performance (Van Dijk and Kluger, 2004, 2011). Furthermore, TMMC facilitates creativity and innovation by enhancing cooperation and encouraging boundary-spanning behavior (Černe *et al.*, 2017).

Importantly, TPMC and TMMC represent separate dimensions of team motivational climate, rather than opposite extremes of a single continuum (Nerstad *et al.*, 2013). TPMC underscores goal-oriented performance, competitive dynamics, and achievement-based evaluation, whereas TMMC emphasizes process-focused learning, collaboration, and knowledge exchange. These distinctions suggest that each climate uniquely influences employee behavior and team dynamics, including the extent to which employees engage in boundary-spanning (Nerstad *et al.*, 2018). Clarifying how these climates shape boundary-spanning behavior offers valuable insight into the mechanisms underlying team motivational climate. By articulating behavioral expectations, organizations can guide employees toward behaviors valued within the workplace (Černe *et al.*, 2014).

Resource-based faultlines at high levels create rigid hierarchical barriers, increasing conformity and reducing accountability among subordinate members. A performance motivational climate further exacerbates this pattern. In high-performance motivational climates, employees often experience negative emotions, such as anxiety and diminished intrinsic motivation, stemming from persistent competition and comparison. When resource-based faultlines are pronounced, employees in high-performance teams face heightened levels of pressure, conflict, and role ambiguity (Aldrich and Herker, 1977). These conditions increase their tendency to conserve existing resources and discourage engagement in boundary-spanning behaviors aimed at acquiring external resources. Moreover, a performance motivational climate reinforces passive and fragmented interactions within teams marked by strong resource-based faultlines, widening the psychological distance between dominant and subordinate groups and amplifying these divisions' adverse consequences (Carton and Cummings, 2012). These conditions foster negative employee interactions (Černe *et al.*, 2014) and reduce the likelihood that employees will proactively engage in boundary-spanning efforts to secure additional resources.

By contrast, resource disparities are less marked in teams with weaker resource-based faultlines. However, intense internal competition can still emerge when the performance motivational climate is high (Pensgaard and Roberts, 2002), as employees strive to outperform peers and gain recognition. Under such conditions, team members may deprioritize boundary-spanning activities to maximize internal performance. When the performance motivational climate is low, employees' learning is not narrowly focused on performance-related goals, and they may engage in exploratory learning driven by personal interest (Zhao *et al.*, 2023). Such exploration can relieve internal tensions and psychological constraints, thereby mitigating the negative effects of resource-based faultlines on boundary-spanning behavior. Therefore, the inhibitory effect of resource-based faultlines on boundary-spanning behavior is more pronounced in teams with a high-performance motivational climate. Based on this reasoning, we propose the following hypothesis:

H3a. Team performance motivational climate positively moderates the negative relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee boundary-spanning behavior, such that this negative relationship is stronger when team performance motivational climate is high compared to when it is low.

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Team mastery motivational climate encourages valuing effort, promoting sharing and collaboration, and underscores continuous learning and skill development (Černe *et al.*, 2014). Within such climates, members are less driven by social comparison and normative standards. This supportive environment enhances interpersonal trust and cooperation, mitigating the negative consequences. Employees are motivated to pursue self-improvement and help peers, promoting knowledge growth through sharing and collaboration (Men *et al.*, 2020). A strong mastery motivational climate fosters an optimal team environment (Valentini and Rudisill, 2006), characterized by mutual support and knowledge exchange, which in turn enhances team cohesion. Under conditions of pronounced resource-based faultlines, this climate buffers adverse effects and supports proactive boundary-spanning behavior. Conversely, a low mastery motivational climate in the context of strong resource-based faultlines is associated with tense internal relationships marked by limited trust and support. Under such conditions, employees are more likely to safeguard their resources and avoid seeking external collaboration, thereby decreasing boundary-spanning activities (Černe *et al.*, 2014; Carton and Cummings, 2012). Thus, a higher mastery motivational climate weakens the adverse effect of resource-based faultlines on employee boundary-spanning behavior. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

H3b. Team mastery motivational climate negatively moderates the negative relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee boundary-spanning behavior, such that this negative relationship is stronger when team mastery motivational climate is low compared to when it is high.

According to COR theory, when individuals perceive a threat of resource loss stemming from group fragmentation, they prioritize preserving current resources and attempt to avoid further depletion (Hobfoll, 1989). This defensive response often manifests as temporary withdrawal and reduced exploratory behaviors (Bal *et al.*, 2020; Hobfoll, 2001). A performance motivational climate produces a competitive environment that may elicit negative emotions and diminish motivation. The divide between “dominant” and “subordinate” subgroups becomes more evident under high-performance motivational climates, thereby intensifying resource competition, especially among members of the subordinate group (Molina *et al.*, 2024; Wei *et al.*, 2024). Within such contexts, employees focus on improving internal performance (Beersma *et al.*, 2003), driven by achievement-oriented goals and the pressure to outperform others. This internal focus on performance may restrict interactions with external stakeholders, reducing boundary-spanning behavior and limiting access to external resources. As a result, employees may experience cognitive narrowing, which hinders the generation of novel and creative ideas (Zhao, 2015), ultimately inhibiting creativity. Based on this analysis, we propose the following hypothesis:

H4a. Team performance motivational climate moderates the indirect effect of team resource-based faultlines on employee creativity via employee boundary-spanning behavior, such that the indirect effect is stronger when team performance motivational climate is high compared to when it is low.

Team mastery motivational climate fosters a sense of shared purpose among team members and actively diminishes social comparisons and group distinctions (Černe *et al.*, 2014). This climate supports positive responses to resource-based faultlines by reducing concerns about power imbalances and the stress associated with continuous social comparisons. While COR theory emphasizes the principle of “loss prioritization”, it also acknowledges that positive resource acquisition can offset resource investment (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018; Lin *et al.*, 2019). The tension related to team resource-based faultlines can be mitigated when individuals perceive opportunities to obtain new resources. Employees may understand that temporary resource expenditure, such as boundary-spanning activities, can generate long-term resource gains and goal attainment (Lin *et al.*, 2019; Halbesleben and Wheeler, 2015). Although resource-based faultlines often reinforce internal power asymmetries (Carton and Cummings, 2012), a strong

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mastery motivational climate reduces individuals' sensitivity to these disparities. This promotes integrating internal knowledge with a diverse external viewpoint through boundary-spanning behavior, which facilitates idea generation and competence enhancement. Furthermore, a high mastery motivational climate also encourages the pursuit of new knowledge and skills, thereby lowering perceived threats posed by resource-based faultlines. Under such circumstances, members are more inclined to engage in boundary-spanning behavior to acquire external knowledge, ultimately promoting creativity. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

H4b. Team mastery motivational climate moderates the indirect effect of team resource-based faultlines on employee creativity via employee boundary-spanning behavior, such that the indirect effect is stronger when team mastery motivational climate is low compared to when it is high.

3. Research methods

3.1 Samples and procedure

This research utilized multi-wave and multi-source data from thirteen high-tech companies in Northern China to investigate the proposed causal relationships. Data were gathered from both team members and their leaders in two phases over two months. In Phase 1, team leaders provided critical information regarding the teams, including team size, composition, and establishment duration. Team members supplied personal demographic details such as age, gender, education level, specialization, functional background, and tenure. They also evaluated their perceptions of resource-based faultlines, team performance motivational climate, and team mastery motivational climate. Two months later, in Phase 2, the same team members reported their boundary-spanning behavior and creativity during the previous two months. Through data collection and a filtering process (excluding teams with fewer than four members), the study gathered a complete sample that included 336 employees across 65 teams, yielding a team response rate of 73.05%. Regarding demographics, 58.6% of participants were male, with an average age of 30.43 years and an average tenure of 4.65 years. Most participants (89%) held at least a bachelor's degree, and team sizes ranged from 4 to 7 members.

3.2 Measures

All survey items were evaluated using a 7-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). We followed standard translation and back-translation procedures to ensure the measurement instruments' semantic equivalence and content validity (Brislin, 1970).

3.2.1 Team resource-based faultlines. We utilized Jehn and Bezrukova's (2010) four-item scale to measure activated team resource-based faultlines, with modifications made to capture team members' shared perceptions of relevant resource attributes. A sample item is, "During team functioning, depending on the control of resources (e.g. power, status, decision-making authority, income), our team forms smaller subgroups at work." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.90. Furthermore, compared to using objective resource data to assess dormant resource-based faultlines, this perceptual approach more accurately reflects the faultlines actively experienced within teams, as it captures the subjective activation of resource divisions (Jehn and Bezrukova, 2010).

3.2.2 Employee boundary-spanning behavior. We used a simplified six-item scale, developed by Marrone *et al.* (2007), to measure employee boundary-spanning behavior. A sample item is, "I made efforts to connect with individuals outside my team to acquire professional knowledge and information relevant to work or tasks." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.89.

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3.2.3 Employee creativity. Team members were asked to evaluate their creativity using the four-item scale developed by Farmer *et al.* (2003). A sample item is, "I proactively try out new ideas or approaches at work." The Cronbach's alpha for this scale was 0.84. Self-assessments of individual creativity tend to be more accurate than peer assessments, as creativity is typically subtle and embedded in daily work processes rather than reflected in outcomes (Subramaniam and Youndt, 2005; Baer and Oldham, 2006). Therefore, others may not fully perceive an individual's actual level of creativity.

3.2.4 Team motivational climate. Team motivational climate was assessed using the work environment scale developed by Nerstad *et al.* (2013), with team performance motivational climate measured by an eight-item subscale. A sample item is, "Team members' performance is often compared with each other." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.93. Additionally, team mastery motivational climate was measured using a six-item subscale. A sample item is, "Team members are prompted to adopt new approaches to solving problems during the work process." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.94.

3.2.5 Control variables. Team size was included as a control variable at the team level, acknowledging that larger teams may possess more resources and influence creativity. Team tenure (measured in years) was also a control variable for potential temporal effects. Previous studies have indicated that team informational and social category faultlines can influence team creativity (Yao *et al.*, 2021; Liu *et al.*, 2021). Therefore, we included these two types of faultlines as team-level control variables. At the individual level, we controlled for demographic factors due to their potential influence on employee creativity. Specifically, this study selected employee tenure and education level as control variables to isolate the effects of the focal variables.

3.3 Analytical approach

We employed Mplus 8.1 to conduct a multilevel path analysis, which was well-suited for the nested structure of our study involving variables operationalized at both the team and employee levels. This approach facilitated hypothesis testing and estimation within and between teams. To enhance the precision of our analysis, team-level variables (e.g. team size, team formation time, resource-based faultlines, informational faultlines, social category faultlines, and team motivational climate) were centered using the grand-mean method. Simultaneously, using the group-mean centering method, we centered individual-level variables such as tenure and education level. We employed the Monte Carlo bootstrapping method to test cross-level indirect effects under moderated mediation, calculating 95% bias-corrected confidence intervals (Bauer *et al.*, 2006).

4. Results

4.1 Data aggregation

To justify aggregating individual-level data to the team-level, we assessed within-team agreement and between-team variance using Rwg(j) (James *et al.*, 1984), ICC (1) (intra-class correlation), and ICC (2) (reliability of group means). The mean Rwg(j) values for team resource-based faultlines, team performance motivational climate, and team mastery motivational climate were 0.78, 0.92, and 0.94, respectively, all exceeding the commonly accepted threshold of 0.70. The corresponding ICC (1) values were 0.19, 0.25, and 0.35, surpassing the 0.10 benchmark, while ICC (2) values were 0.47, 0.61, and 0.72. Although the ICC (2) value for team resource-based faultlines was below Glick's (1985) recommended threshold of 0.60, this is likely due to the relatively small team sizes in the sample (James, 1982). To further support aggregation, we followed Newman and Sin's (2020) recommendation to compute ρ_{wg}, which yielded a value of 0.72, indicating sufficient within-group agreement and supporting the decision to aggregate data at the team level.

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4.2 Confirmatory factor analyses

We conducted a multilevel confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to verify the structure of five key constructs: team resource-based faultlines, team performance motivational climate, team mastery motivational climate, employee boundary-spanning behavior, and employee creativity. These constructs were evaluated at both the individual and team levels to ensure consistency in the factor structure across levels. As shown in Table 1, the five-factor model, which treated each variable as a separate latent construct, exhibited an acceptable fit to the data ($RMSEA = 0.04$, $CFI = 0.93$, $TLI = 0.92$, $SRMR(\text{within}) = 0.04$, $SRMR(\text{between}) = 0.09$). This model demonstrated superior fit compared to all alternative models, providing strong evidence for the distinctiveness of the constructs. The results further confirmed the discriminant validity of the measures used in the study.

4.3 Descriptive statistics and correlations

Table 2 presents the variables' means, standard deviations, and correlations. As anticipated, the findings indicated that, at the individual level, employee boundary-spanning behavior was positively related to employee creativity ($r = 0.51, p < 0.01$). Additionally, at the team level, after accounting for team size, team tenure, informational faultlines, and social category faultlines, a positive correlation was observed between team resource-based faultlines and team mastery motivational climate ($r = 0.53, p < 0.01$), as well as between team performance motivational climate and team mastery motivational climate ($r = 0.19, p < 0.01$).

4.4 Hypothesis testing

To test the theoretical hypothesis, we used a two-level analytical model (TYPE = TWOLEVEL). Hypothesis 1 proposed an adverse effect of team resource-based faultlines on employee boundary-spanning behavior. Model 1 in Table 3 demonstrates that, after controlling for employee education level, tenure, team size, team tenure, social category faultlines, and informational faultlines, team resource-based faultlines show a significant negative relationship with employee boundary-spanning behavior ($\gamma = -0.23, s.e. = 0.08, p < 0.05$). Thus, Hypothesis 1 was supported.

We tested the mediating effect using a multilevel regression model (MSEM) in Mplus 8.1. The hypothesis was that employee boundary-spanning behavior mediates the relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee creativity. Table 4 presents the results of the mediation analysis. In this model, employee boundary-spanning behavior positively affects employee creativity ($\gamma = 0.62, s.e. = 0.17, p < 0.01$), supporting Hypothesis 2. The multiplication of the two-stage coefficients (indirect effect) is also significant ($\gamma = -0.15, s.e. = 0.06, p < 0.05$). Furthermore, Monte Carlo simulation tests indicate that the 95% confidence interval is [−0.27, −0.03], excluding 0. These results confirm the

Table 1. Multilevel confirmatory factor analyses

Model	χ^2	*df*	χ^2/df	RMSEA	CFI	TLI	SRMR (within)	SRMR (between)
1. Five-factor hypothesized model	575.60	374	1.54	0.04	0.93	0.92	0.04	0.09
2. Four-factor model	993.82	378	2.63	0.07	0.79	0.76	0.05	0.20
3. Three-factor model	1239.08	382	3.24	0.08	0.71	0.67	0.13	0.23
4. Two-factor model	1387.01	384	3.61	0.09	0.64	0.60	0.13	0.24

Note(s): Four-factor model: TRBF and TPMC were combined in one factor; Three-factor model: TRBF, TPMC, and TMMC were combined in one factor; Two-factor model: TRBF, TPMC, and TMMC were combined in one factor, and BSB with EC were combined in one factor

Source(s): Authors' own work

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Table 2. Descriptive statistics and correlations of variables

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Individual-level variables									
1. Education level	3.10	0.61	–						
2. Tenure	4.66	5.02	0.11*	–					
3. Boundary-spanning behavior	5.18	0.84	−0.03	−0.05	–				
4. Employee creativity	5.16	0.80	−0.07	−0.08	0.51**	–			
Team-level variables									
1. Team size	5.38	1.07	–						
2. Team tenure	5.77	5.69	0.23**	–					
3. Team informational faultlines	0.60	0.16	0.42**	−0.02	–				
4. Social category faultlines	0.54	0.13	0.32**	0.05	0.15**	–			
5. Team resource-based faultlines	2.66	0.66	−0.10*	0.05	0.15**	0.07	–		
6. Team performance motivational climate	4.95	0.67	−0.12**	0.02	−0.05	−0.01	0.12*	–	
7. Team mastery motivational climate	5.46	0.52	−0.08	−0.05	0.30**	−0.05	0.53**	0.19**	–

Note(s): $N = 336$ for individual-level data, $N = 65$ for team-level data; *$p < 0.05$. **$p < 0.01$
Source(s): Authors' own work

Table 3. Results of the multilevel effects test

Predictors	Employee boundary-spanning behavior Model 1 Estimate	S.E	Model 2 Estimate	S.E	Model 3 Estimate	S.E
Intercept	5.03**	0.50	5.04**	0.57	4.97**	0.52
Individual-level						
Education level	0.01	0.01	−0.02	0.12	−0.02	0.12
Tenure	−0.02	0.12	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01
Team-level						
Team size	0.03	0.08	0.05	0.07	0.05	0.08
Team tenure	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.01
Team informational faultlines	−0.43	0.37	−0.44	0.36	−0.5	0.54
Social category faultlines	−0.22	0.48	−0.30	0.50	0.01	0.01
Team resource-based faultlines	−0.23*	0.08	−0.26**	0.07	−0.32**	0.08
Team performance motivational climate			0.12	0.09		
Team mastery motivational climate					0.17	0.18
TRBF × TPMC			−0.18*	0.10		
TRBF × TMMC					0.28**	0.13

Note(s): $N = 336$ for individual-level data, $N = 65$ for team-level data; *$p < 0.05$. **$p < 0.01$
Source(s): Authors' own work

mediating role of employee boundary-spanning behavior in the relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee creativity, thereby providing further support for Hypothesis 2.

In Hypothesis 3a, we proposed that team performance motivational climate amplifies the negative relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee boundary-

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Table 4. Results of the mediating effect for employee boundary-spanning behavior

Path	Estimate	S.E	95%CI
TRBF→BSB	-0.24^{**}	0.09	[−0.42, −0.07]
BSB→EC	0.62^{**}	0.17	[0.28, 0.96]
TRBF→BSB→EC			
Indirect effect	-0.15^{*}	0.06	[−0.27, −0.03]

Note(s): $N = 336$ for individual-level data, $N = 65$ for team-level data; *$p < 0.05$. **$p < 0.01$
Source(s): Authors' own work

spanning behavior. Model 2 in Table 3 supports this, as the interaction term between team performance motivational climate and team resource-based faultlines is significantly negatively correlated with employee boundary-spanning behavior ($\gamma = -0.18, s.e. = 0.10, p < 0.05$), supporting Hypothesis 3a. To further interpret the moderating effect, we plotted the mean of team performance motivational climate plus or minus one standard deviation as high or low and presented the results in Figure 2. When team performance motivational climate is low, the negative relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee boundary-spanning behavior is insignificant ($b = -0.16, ns$). However, when team performance motivational climate is high, this negative relationship becomes significant ($b = -0.49, p < 0.05$), further supporting Hypothesis 3a.

In Hypothesis 3b, we proposed that team mastery motivational climate weakens the negative relationship between team resource-based faultlines and employee boundary-spanning behavior. Model 3 in Table 3 supports this, showing a significant positive association between the interaction term of team mastery motivational climate and team resource-based faultlines with employee boundary-spanning behavior ($\gamma = 0.28, s.e. = 0.13, p < 0.01$), thus supporting Hypothesis 3b. To further clarify this moderating influence, we plotted the mean of team mastery motivational climate plus or minus one standard deviation for high and low values, as shown in Figure 3. When team mastery motivational climate is low, there is a significant negative correlation between team resource-based faultlines and employee boundary-spanning behavior ($b = -0.45, p < 0.01$). When team mastery motivational climate is high, the relationship is insignificant ($b = 0.03, ns$), offering additional support for Hypothesis 3b.

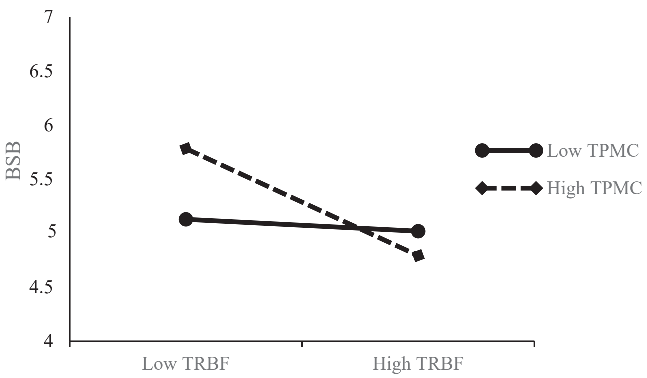

Figure 2. The moderating effect of team performance motivational climate on the relationship between team resource-based faultlines and boundary-spanning behavior. **Source(s):** Authors' own work

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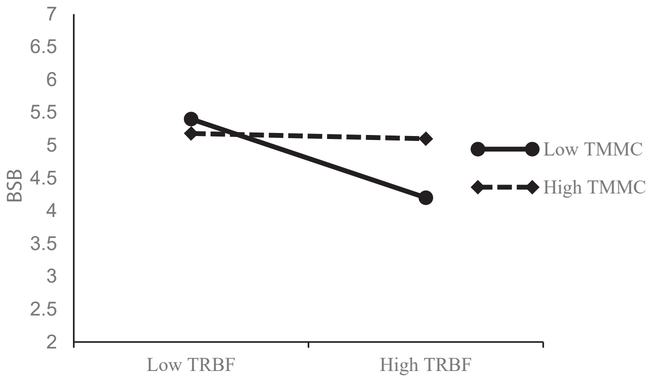

Figure 3. The moderating effect of team mastery motivational climate on the relationship between team resource-based faultlines and boundary-spanning behavior. **Source(s):** Authors' own work

To test the moderated mediation proposed in Hypothesis 4, we followed Edwards and Lambert's (2007) procedure to compare the conditional indirect effects of team motivational climate at low (−1 SD) and high (+1 SD) levels. Hypothesis 4a proposed that team performance motivational climate positively moderates the indirect effect of team resource-based faultlines on employee creativity through employee boundary-spanning behavior. Table 5 shows that the mediating effect of boundary-spanning behavior is significant under high team performance motivational climate ($conditional\ indirect = -0.19, s.e. = 0.05, CI_{95\%} = [-0.29, -0.06]$), but insignificant under low team performance motivational climate ($conditional\ indirect = -0.06, s.e. = 0.03, CI_{95\%} = [-0.13, 0.02]$). The difference estimate is also significant ($difference = -0.13, s.e. = 0.05, CI_{95\%} = [-0.18, -0.01]$), supporting Hypothesis 4a. Hypothesis 4b proposed that team mastery motivational climate negatively moderates the indirect effect of team resource-based faultlines on employee creativity through employee boundary-spanning behavior. The mediating effect of employee boundary-spanning behavior is significant under high team mastery motivational climate ($conditional\ indirect = -0.10, s.e. = 0.05, CI_{95\%} = [-0.21, -0.05]$). In comparison, it is also significant under low team mastery motivational climate ($conditional\ indirect = -0.20, s.e. = 0.06, CI_{95\%} = [-0.34, -0.07]$), with the difference being significant ($difference = 0.10, s.e. = 0.05, CI_{95\%} = [0.01, 0.22]$). These findings confirm the moderated mediation effects and support Hypothesis 4b.

Together, these results provide robust evidence for the moderated mediation mechanism, highlighting how the two types of team motivational climate differentially influence the indirect pathway from team resource-based faultlines to employee creativity through boundary-spanning behavior.

Table 5. Results of moderated mediation effects

Variables		Estimate	S.E	95%CI
TPMC	High TPMC	−0.19**	0.05	[−0.29, −0.06]
	Low TPMC	−0.06	0.03	[−0.13, 0.02]
	Difference	−0.13*	0.05	[−0.18, −0.01]
TMMC	High TMMC	−0.10*	0.05	[−0.21, −0.05]
	Low TMMC	−0.20**	0.06	[−0.34, −0.07]
	Difference	0.10*	0.05	[0.01, 0.22]

Note(s): $N = 336$ for individual-level data, $N = 65$ for team-level data; *$p < 0.05$. **$p < 0.01$
Source(s): Authors' own work

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5. Discussion

Resource-based faultlines constitute a critical dimension for understanding team dynamics, especially as teams mature and accumulate experience through sustained collaboration. Employee creativity, essential for innovative team performance, often depends on members' ability to generate novel ideas through open and unrestrained social interactions (Lee *et al.*, 2018). This study applies COR theory as its theoretical framework to investigate how resource-based faultlines affect employee creativity. It offers a nuanced understanding of the complex mechanisms through which resource-based faultlines shape creative behavior. The specific conclusions are as follows.

First, we found that resource-based faultlines indirectly reduce employee creativity by diminishing boundary-spanning behavior, thereby providing strong support for the mediating role of this behavior. This finding broadly aligns with the COR theory (Hobfoll, 2001), which posits that in environments characterized by intense resource conflict, employees tend to conserve their limited resources and are less likely to engage in extra-role behaviors such as boundary-spanning (Bruning and Campion, 2018). Consequently, they encounter greater difficulty accessing diverse external resources, which hampers creative development. Our finding also resonates with the work of Greer *et al.* (2017), who argued that the emergence of power factions in teams heightens members' sensitivity to resource distribution and undermines individual outcomes. In addition, it is consistent with prior studies demonstrating that boundary-spanning behavior enhances both task and creative performance (Liu *et al.*, 2018; Zhang and Li, 2024). By uncovering this mediating mechanism, our study also responds to Yao and Liu's (2023) call for further exploration of how resource-based faultlines affect employee outcomes.

Second, this study revealed that the two dimensions of team motivational climate, namely team performance motivational climate and team mastery motivational climate, have opposite moderating effects on the cross-level relationship between resource-based faultlines and employee creativity. Specifically, a strong mastery climate helps buffer the negative influence of resource-based faultlines by fostering a supportive and collaborative team environment that promotes knowledge sharing and mutual assistance. This cooperative atmosphere mitigates intra-team tensions, thereby facilitating the development of creative ideas. In contrast, a strong performance climate strengthens the adverse effects of resource-based faultlines. Encouraging comparison, competition, and pressure to outperform others may intensify perceptions of internal division and exacerbate power struggles, ultimately inhibiting employee creativity. These findings align with Wu *et al.* (2024), who reported that mastery and performance motivational climates moderated the relationship between workplace suspicion and knowledge hiding in opposing directions. Together, these findings respond to the call by Greer *et al.* (2017) for a more contextualized understanding of how power dynamics operate within team settings, especially under conditions of resource asymmetry. They also echo Guillaume *et al.* (2017)'s recommendation to further explore boundary conditions that influence the effects of team faultlines.

5.1 Theoretical implications

Our study offers several notable contributions to the existing body of literature. First, this research makes a significant and timely contribution to the study of team faultlines by shifting the focus from traditional demographic and informational faultlines (Bezrukova *et al.*, 2009) to the more potent yet underexplored resource-based faultlines. This study demonstrates how resource disparities, deeply embedded within team structures, can profoundly shape members' attitudes, behaviors, and creative performance. By exploring the effects of resource-based faultlines on creativity, the research broadens the understanding of team dynamics and adds to the existing literature on employee creativity (Anderson *et al.*, 2014). While previous studies have emphasized the role of cognitive diversity in fostering innovative ideas (Shin *et al.*, 2012), this study underscores how resource-based faultlines introduce social and power

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dynamics that can hinder creativity. Overall, this study not only lays a theoretical foundation for understanding how resource-based faultlines affect employee outcomes, but also offers a novel power-dynamics perspective on the antecedents of employee creativity.

Second, we adopt a novel "within and outside team" perspective to identify boundary-spanning behavior as a critical mechanism linking resource-based faultlines to employee creativity. Unlike prior research that treats teams as closed systems and emphasizes internal cognitive or emotional processes (Qu and Liu, 2017; Ma *et al.*, 2022; Yao and Liu, 2023), we shift the analytical lens outward to show how faultlines influence employees' engagement with external knowledge and resources (Marrone *et al.*, 2007). By empirically validating the mediating role of boundary-spanning behavior, we uncover a previously underexplored explanatory pathway and address the limitations of studies concentrating solely on intra-team mechanisms (Yao *et al.*, 2022; Joshi *et al.*, 2009; Salem *et al.*, 2018). This research also contributes to the boundary-spanning literature by advancing understanding of its antecedents and consequences.

Lastly, this study reveals the differentiated moderating effects of mastery and performance motivational climates in the relationship between resource-based faultlines and employee creativity, contributing a novel viewpoint to the literature on team diversity and motivational climate. While prior research has explored various team characteristics and environmental factors as moderators (Nishii and Goncalo, 2008; Antino *et al.*, 2019; Kunze and Bruch, 2010; Mitchell and Boyle, 2021; Bezrukova *et al.*, 2012; Richard *et al.*, 2019), the contrasting roles of motivational climates have received limited attention, with most studies focusing on either mastery or performance climates in isolation (Men *et al.*, 2020; He *et al.*, 2023). By demonstrating that a performance motivational climate amplifies, whereas a mastery motivational climate buffers, the adverse effects of resource-based faultlines, this study provides a more comprehensive understanding of the boundary conditions under which resource-based faultlines affect employee behavior and creativity. Theoretically, this research expands the scope of team faultlines research by integrating motivational climate as a critical contextual moderator, thereby providing a solid foundation for future studies to explore how different motivational climates influence individual outcomes in diverse team contexts.

5.2 Practical implications

This study presents several important practical implications. Firstly, in addition to addressing commonly discussed faultlines such as informational and social category faultlines, team leaders must also focus on resource-based faultlines that stem from unequal access to power, status, and decision-making authority. Although these faultlines are often less visible, their impact on collaboration and employee creativity can be profound if left unaddressed. To mitigate these effects, leaders should regularly monitor team dynamics, remain alert to the signs of resource-based disparities, and ensure that the voices of subordinate subgroups' members are recognized and valued. Effective management involves implementing strategic and context-sensitive resource allocation practices that strike an appropriate balance between equity and equality, tailored to the specific needs and tasks of the team, as recognizing and rewarding the contributions of high-performing members can, under certain conditions, enhance overall team efficiency (Yu *et al.*, 2018). This consideration is significant in hierarchical cultural contexts, such as China, where unchecked disparities can reinforce divisions. By actively managing these faultlines, leaders can foster greater team cohesion and psychological safety, critical to promoting innovation and improving overall team performance (Jehn and Bezrukova, 2010).

Secondly, encouraging boundary-spanning behavior is essential for enhancing employee creativity. Managers should actively promote employee engagement in such activities by providing necessary support and cultivating a strong sense of psychological safety. Recognizing and rewarding boundary-spanning efforts can be effective motivators, such as offering promotion opportunities or public recognition. In addition, encouraging employees to

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apply new technologies and knowledge can further stimulate their innovative performance. However, managers must also recognize that allocating resources within a team can influence these behaviors. Managers should design resource distribution to facilitate cross-team collaboration rather than reinforce internal silos (Marrone, 2010).

Finally, fostering a supportive team climate is crucial for teams experiencing resource-based faultlines. Our findings reveal that a team performance motivational climate amplifies the influence of these faultlines on employee creativity, while a mastery motivational climate can mitigate this effect. Therefore, managers should intentionally cultivate a motivational climate that promotes learning and growth. Specifically, to build a culture of mutual learning, leaders can encourage employees to acquire new knowledge, share resources openly, and engage in constructive dialogue. This type of climate fosters innovation, collaboration, and continuous development within the team (Hülsheger *et al.*, 2009). Simultaneously, managers should remain attentive to the potential downsides of a performance motivational climate. Early detection of excessive comparison and competition and reduced performance-related pressure is essential to guide employees toward healthy motivation and purposeful collaboration. Striking the right balance between these climates will help sustain employee creativity and team effectiveness.

5.3 Limitations and directions for future research

Although this study provides theoretical and practical contributions, several potential limitations should be acknowledged. First, as our study collected data on team resource-based faultlines, employee boundary-spanning behavior, team motivational climate, and employee creativity from a single source (e.g. employees), there is a potential risk of common methodological bias (CMV, Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). We employed a two-wave data collection design to mitigate this bias with a two-month interval between measurements. However, the study lacks an experimental design for establishing causal inferences regarding the observed relationships. Future research could further explore the causal effects of resource-based faultlines through situational experimental studies, such as virtual reality technology or field experiments. These approaches would better simulate real-life scenarios, thereby enhancing the ecological validity of the study.

Second, this study indicates that high resource-based faultlines hinder employee creativity by constraining boundary-spanning behavior, with team motivational climate moderating this mediating relationship. Nevertheless, other potential mediators and moderators in the relationship between resource-based faultlines and employee creativity warrant further investigation. Prior research has shown that power struggles can adversely affect team performance (Greer and van Kleef, 2010; Bendersky and Hays, 2012), yet their effects on individual employee behavior and creativity remain underexplored. In addition to the team motivational climate, team hierarchical legitimacy may serve as a promising boundary condition (Doyle and Lount, 2023). Therefore, future research should incorporate a variety of mediators and moderators to facilitate a more comprehensive and profound understanding of how resource-based faultlines impact individual employees.

Third, this study exclusively employed employee creativity as the dependent variable, without differentiating among creativity subtypes, thereby overlooking potential differences in the underlying mechanisms. Scholars such as Madjar *et al.* (2011) have classified employee creativity into radical creativity and incremental creativity, providing a more nuanced framework for understanding creativity. Accordingly, future research should examine whether resource-based faultlines affect radical versus incremental creativity differently.

Finally, because this study collected data exclusively from Chinese firms, it is important to recognize the potential influences of cultural factors on employees' judgments and behaviors. Cultural characteristics such as collectivism and deference to hierarchical order may amplify the negative impact of resource-based faultlines in this context. As a result, researchers should exercise caution when generalizing these findings to different cultural or organizational

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contexts. To enhance the external validity of these results, future research should actively examine whether similar patterns emerge in more diverse cultural environments.

6. Conclusion

Our findings indicate that resource-based faultlines at the team level exert a cross-level negative effect on employee creativity, with employee boundary-spanning behavior serving as a crucial mediator in this relationship. Additionally, this study provides empirical evidence that team performance motivational climate and team mastery motivational climate play different moderating roles in the dynamic relationship between resource-based faultlines and employee creativity. These results advance the theoretical understanding of team faultlines in organizational research and offer practical insights for managing team composition and fostering a conducive team climate.

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